

Catch up: Trump insists Iran talks have resumed; Palantir raises revenue forecast



Photograph: Bloomberg via Getty Images

Donald Trump called **Iran** “unbelievably duplicitous” for denying that it is negotiating with **America**. Mr Trump insisted that talks had resumed on Monday, describing them as Iran’s “last chance” for a deal. Iran said it is discussing the management of the [Strait of Hormuz](#) with Oman only. Still, American markets rallied and the price of Brent crude dropped by around 5% on hopes of diplomacy.

Palantir raised its annual revenue forecast to around \$8.15bn after reporting “staggering” second-quarter growth. [The software company](#) previously estimated revenue of roughly \$7.65bn this year. Palantir’s quarterly revenue rose 93% year on year, to \$1.94bn, as government and commercial sales accelerated in America. Profits grew by 55%, to \$1.06bn.

Two Republican senators backed **Todd Blanche’s** nomination as [America’s attorney-general](#), days after threatening to withhold their support. John Cornyn and Thom Tillis reversed course after Mr Blanche formally rescinded parts of a deal the Justice Department had struck with Mr Trump, including provisions creating a [\\$1.8bn “Anti-Weaponisation Fund”](#). Mr Blanche also clarified the limits of the president’s immunity from audits.

Reform UK escalated its anti-migrant rhetoric with a pledge to launch a “military” crackdown on small-boat crossings into Britain if elected. After more than a year leading polls, [Britain’s populist-right party](#) recently dropped below the ruling Labour (whose unpopular leader stepped down last month), according to *The Economist’s* [poll tracker](#). Its firebrand leader, Nigel Farage, faces growing scrutiny over his personal finances.

Visa is buying BioCatch, a software company that uses artificial intelligence to detect fraud, for \$2.4bn in cash. The digital payments giant said the deal would protect its customers from the increasing threat of [scams](#) and account hacks, which AI is enabling “at unprecedented scale”. Visa said it has invested more than \$13bn in fraud safeguards in the last five years.

After almost a decade of safety reviews, America’s Federal Aviation Administration certified **Boeing’s 737 MAX-7** aircraft for commercial use. The planemaker faced tough regulatory scrutiny following two fatal crashes and [production malfunctions](#), all of which involved other 737 MAX models. Boeing said it will deliver the first plane to Southwest, an American carrier. Its shares rose on the news.

Could you place **Naoero** on a map? The world’s third-smallest country by population, a tiny island in the South Pacific, officially changed its name. The government said its previous name, Nauru, was adopted to help foreigners spell and pronounce it, but did not reflect its “heritage”, “language” and “identity”. Naoero follows [eSwatini](#), which ditched its colonial name, Swaziland, in 2018.

Figure of the day: 36%, Europe’s share of global heat deaths, despite having just 10% of the world’s population. [Read about how the geopolitics of air-conditioning](#) plays a role.

Deal or no deal?



Photograph: ABEDIN TAHERKENAREH/EPA/Shutterstock

He did it again. Donald Trump's administration spent much of last week hinting that America was prepared to launch a massive attack on Iran. But on Saturday the president announced that he had shelved the assault because—why else?—he was on the precipice of an agreement with Iran. Later he said that new talks to end the war would start on Monday. This [cycle of threat and retreat](#) has become routine over the past few months. Mr Trump had plenty of reasons not to escalate. America's allies in the Gulf feared Iran would hit them hard. Pentagon planners fret about dwindling supplies of air-defence interceptors.

But it is unclear what deal he claims to be close to. The previous agreement, the so-called memorandum of understanding signed in June, collapsed last month after Iran refused to reopen the Strait of Hormuz. Diplomats from Oman have tried to mediate a compromise in which regional countries would establish a consortium to control the strait. But Iran rejected the idea. The cycle continues.

A status check for summer travel



Photograph: Getty Images

Three travel companies, Marriott, Booking Holdings and Airbnb, all report earnings this week. Their results will help investors assess a summer-holiday season unusually affected by global events. Strong demand from World Cup fans in North America was good news for hoteliers. Dampened Middle East sales due to America's and Israel's war with Iran was not.

If the second-quarter earnings posted last week by Hilton, a competitor, are anything to go by, the upcoming crop of results will be decidedly mixed. Hilton beat Wall Street expectations, in large part due to strong demand from football fanatics. Yet revenues per available room, a key industry metric, in the Middle East were lacklustre. They were in China, too, chiefly because of restrictions on outbound group tours—most notably to Japan, following a series of [diplomatic spats](#) over Taiwan. Such factors may explain why, despite rising revenue, Hilton's stock fell more than 3% on the results. There's no checking out from geopolitics.

What next for the boss of the beautiful game?



Photograph: AFP

Just a fortnight ago, Gianni Infantino—the head of FIFA, football’s governing body, —handed [Spain](#) the World Cup trophy in a jubilant mood. The tournament had been contentious, but it also raked in a record-breaking \$15bn. Yet Mr Infantino wanted more. Last week he unveiled a plan to sell stakes in a new entity, valued at \$20bn, to help run the World Cup and unlock “previously uncaptured commercial value”.

This proved to be an own goal. Pushback was fierce, led by football associations across Europe, Asia and the Americas who were incensed by both the concept and the lack of consultation. The furore forced FIFA to withdraw the plan on Friday. But the fallout will probably last longer: some of the organisation’s members hope to dismiss Mr Infantino in the coming weeks (he faces re-election in 2027) and are calling for governance reforms. The organisation, though, is [no stranger to scandals](#). Mr Infantino may get a red card, but that won’t necessarily change the game.

Attempts to take over easyJet hit turbulence



Photograph: Getty Images

A battle over easyJet may soon be concluded. The initial takeover bid from Castlelake, an American investment firm, was £5.60 (\$7.55) a share—several overtures later, easyJet’s board finally accepted a boosted offer of £6.90. But a couple of days later Apollo, another American investor, swooped in with a bid of £7.15 a share, which the board then accepted instead.

On Monday easyJet gave Castlelake until Friday to raise its bid or take off (the original deadline was Monday). Who wins will be consequential for the airline. Castlelake may want the company to be [broken up](#): easyJet’s holiday business, current fleet and order book for new planes are all significant assets. But Apollo has pledged to stick with the company’s current strategy of upgrading its planes and expanding its holiday packages. This, it reckons, could generate £1bn in pre-tax profits in the medium term—meaning it will take Apollo a little while to recoup the total £5.7bn it is currently offering.

Daily quiz



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Monday: What happens on the Orient Express in the title of the Agatha Christie novel?

*Better to doubt methodically than
to think capriciously.*

Stanley Baldwin